

First Read

China Brokers Sector

CSRC derivatives measures: structuring growth, favouring leaders

Equities

China
Financial Services

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CSRC rolled out the first departmental rules governing derivatives

CSRC issued '[Measures for Supervision and Administration of Derivatives Trading \(Trial\)](#)' ('the Measures'), the first comprehensive departmental rules specifically governing derivatives. The Measures signals a shift toward a more standardized and orderly market. While near-term growth may face some pressure, the Measures lay the groundwork for more disciplined and regulated leverage over time. For intermediaries (e.g., securities and futures firms), tighter requirements on capital, classification, segregation, and reporting would raise operating costs, and therefore may potentially accelerate industry consolidation and favouring leading players. The Measures will take effect on 16 November, implying a six-month grace period. From then, non-compliant firms shall not launch new business, and existing positions must be unwound upon maturity. The Measures apply only to CSRC-regulated trading venues and intermediaries, excluding interbank and bank/insurance OTC markets.

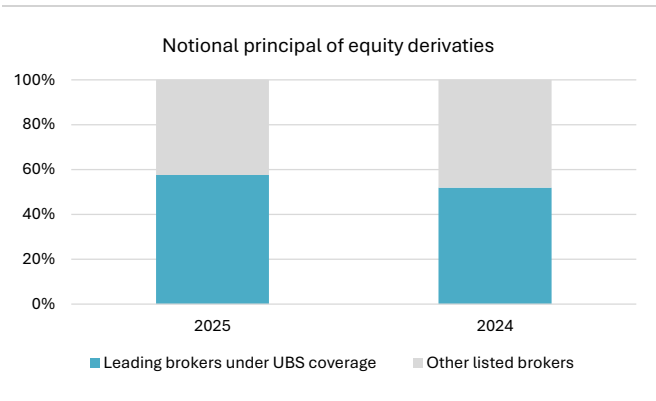
Building toward long-term upside; leading players well positioned

We believe the roll-out of the Measures signals China's derivatives market shifting toward more standardized and orderly development. Near-term growth may soften as non-compliant products shall be phased out and smaller players with weaker capital bases may exit. However, the Measures open up room for more disciplined and regulated usage of leverage. Leading players should benefit disproportionately, backed by strong capital and scale to meet tighter rules while delivering compliant products. CITICS, CICC, HTSC, and GTHT jointly accounted for nearly 60% (UBS-e) of notional principal of equity derivatives of all listed brokers in 2025 (vs. 2024: ~52%). China's derivatives market remains underpenetrated, especially in financial derivatives. Globally, financial derivatives make up the majority of exchange-traded volumes, versus 33%/20% (value/volume, UBS-e) in China in 2025. Growth should be driven by rising institutionalization and increasing foreign participation as markets open up.

Key highlights in the Measures

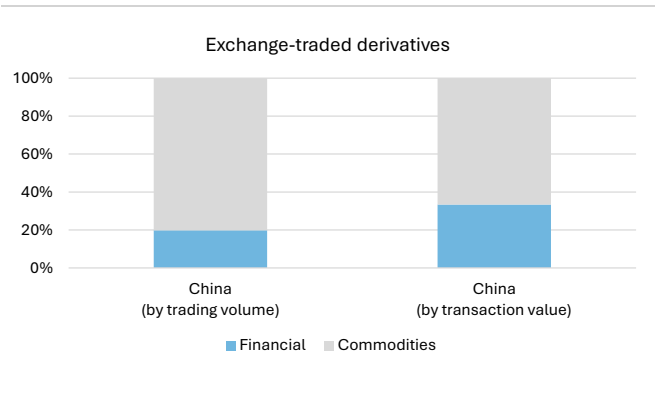
Compared with the draft for public consultation ([issued on 16 Jan](#)), the finalized trial version **(1) set a clear bar for securities and futures firms**, requiring net capital of at least Rmb500 mn over the past six months. The CSRC may adjust this minimum under prudent supervision. We believe this favours well-capitalized leading players and could accelerate industry consolidation. **(2) broadened trading restrictions**, extending the ban on derivatives activity by listed companies, major shareholders, controllers and executives from their own shares to all equity-like securities. The phase-out of non-compliant structured products may weigh on near-term growth, and **(3) clarified scope**, defining derivatives as swaps, forwards, and non-standardized options (including combinations), excluding futures. In addition, the Measures **clarified the role of derivatives**: promoting hedging while curbing excessive speculation. This implies likely tighter scrutiny across product design, investor suitability, and leverage controls, with tools such as margin requirements, position limits, and countercyclical measures. Corporates could leverage derivatives to hedge risk exposures. Listed companies are required to follow formal governance procedures and disclose relevant activities.

Figure 1: Leading brokers' share in notional principal of equity derivatives expanded



Source: Company data, UBS estimates. Note: leading brokers under UBS coverage include CITICS, CICC, HTSC and GTHT.

Figure 2: Commodities derivatives dominating exchange-traded in China



Source: Wind, UBS estimates. Note: Trading volume and transaction value data are based on 2025 figures.

Valuation Method and Risk Statement

We believe main risks to China's securities sector include: 1) a market downturn and greater access to licenses, leading to increased industry competition; 2) risk of sustained commission decreases; 3) the scale of margin financing, share pledges and other capital intermediary services is lower than expected and thus contributes less to earnings than expected; 4) regulatory penalties; 5) innovation-related failures that could lead to reputational loss, the loss of customers, lawsuits or other risks; and 6) lower-than-expected earnings or other risks due to fluctuations in investment income.

CITIC-A/H: Our price target is based on P/BV-ROE methodology for CITIC-A and DDM for CITIC-H. We think the main upside risks for the stock include: 1) higher-than-expected activity in the A-share market; 2) decreasing regulatory risk; and 3) faster-than-expected business development driving earnings to overshoot estimates. The main downside risks include: 1) brokers experiencing lower earnings and de-rating amid a protracted A-share slump; 2) slower-than-expected progress in innovative segments; and 3) large-scale employee turnover leading to sharp declines in market share and earnings.

Huatai-A/H: Our price target is based on P/BV-ROE for Huatai-A and DDM for Huatai-H. We believe key downside risks facing the company include: the opening-up of off-site account opening, internet applications and increasing lite outlets (engaged in trading and margin financing only) could intensify brokerage competition, causing commission rates to decline in the medium-to-long-term; if debt financing increases and interest expenses rise, margin financing, share pledges and other capital intermediary services may make less-than-expected earnings contribution; failure in innovation may lead to reputational damage, customer losses, litigation, regulatory penalties, etc; volatile securities market investment return, persistently sluggish trading, etc.

CICC-H: Our price target is based on DDM for CICC-H. We think the main downside risks include: 1) brokers experiencing lower earnings and downward re-ratings amid a protracted A-share slump; 2) slower-than-expected progress in innovative segments; and 3) fiercer competition in the brokerage business and declining commission rates in the medium to long term.

GTHT-A: Our price target is based on a P/BV-ROE methodology. Downside risks include: 1) disappointing outcomes from the merger; 2) weaker-than-expected profit contributions from capital intermediary services such as margin financing and equity pledge loans amid higher debt financing and interest expenses; 3) continued volatility in investment returns, subdued market trading activity; and 4) the risk of Haitong International remaining loss-making in its investment operations.

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Source: UBS. Rating allocations are as of 31 March 2026.

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Company Name	Reuters	12-month rating	Price	Price date
CITIC Securities - A ^{16,7,18a,6a}	600030.SS	Buy	Rmb26.35	15 May 2026
CITIC Securities - H ^{16,7,18a,6a}	6030.HK	Buy	HK\$26.50	15 May 2026
China International Capital - H ^{28,7,18a}	3908.HK	Buy	HK\$20.42	15 May 2026
Guotai Haitong Securities - A ^{4,28,7,18a,6a,18b,6b}	601211.SS	Buy	Rmb15.44	15 May 2026
Huatai Securities - A ^{2,13,4,5,28,7,18a,6a,6c}	601688.SS	Buy	Rmb18.52	15 May 2026
Huatai Securities - H ^{2,13,4,5,28,7,18a,6a,6c}	6886.HK	Buy	HK\$16.13	15 May 2026

Source: UBS Global Research; LSEG Eikon. All prices as of local market close. Ratings in this table are the most current published ratings prior to this report. They may be more recent than the stock pricing date.

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